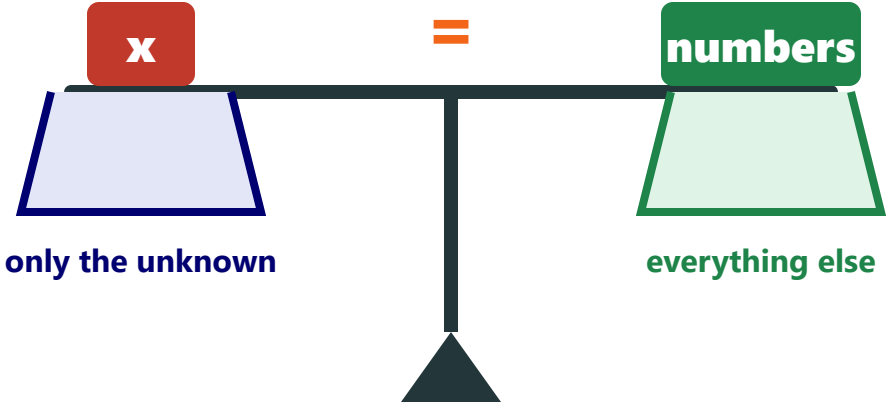
What does “isolating” a quantity mean?



To isolate a quantity (to “clear” it, *despejar* in Spanish) means to leave it **completely alone** on one side of the equals sign:

✓ with **nothing** added, subtracted, multiplied or divided next to it,

✓ in the **numerator** (on top), never below the fraction line,

✓ and with everything else on the **other side**.

$x = 4$

✓ isolated

$2x = 8$

✗ it is multiplied by 2

$x + 3 = 7$

✗ it has a 3 added

$\frac{1}{x} = 5$

✗ it is below the line